

## 10.3 Using XP's Firewall

A firewall is a hardware or software solution to enforce security policies. To use a physical analogy, a firewall permits only authorised users—such as those with a key or access card—to enter. A firewall has inbuilt filters that can disallow potentially dangerous material from entering the system. It also logs attempted intrusions.

An important thing to note about a firewall is that it implements an access control policy. The firewall's configuration imposes its policy on everything behind it.

In cases where a company's policies dictate how data must be protected, a firewall turns out to be very important. Some firewalls permit only e-mail traffic through them, thereby protecting the network against any attacks other than attacks against the e-mail service. Other firewalls provide less strict protections, and block services that are known to be problems.

Generally, firewalls are configured to protect against unauthenticated logins from the outside world. More advanced firewalls block traffic from the outside to the inside, but permit users on the inside to communicate freely with the outside.

Windows XP includes an inbuilt Firewall. It protects a single computer connected to the Internet. In SP2, the Firewall is enabled by default. If you don't have SP2 and want to enable the firewall, go to Control Panel > Windows Firewall (if you don't find this in the Control Panel, switch to Classic View) and enable it from there.



The Windows Firewall dialog



The Advanced settings